kharif crop, starting in June with the beginning of the southwest monsoon and ending in October-November, on the other side of the monsoon. Some of the largest tomato-producing states are Madhya Pradesh (13.4 per cent share), Karnataka (12.6 per cent), Andhra Pradesh (11.3 per cent), Gujarat (7.2 per cent), Odisha (7 per cent), West Bengal and Maharashtra (6 per cent each). "For states such as Gujarat, production has fallen by 23.9 per cent, and for Tamil Nadu and Chhattisgarh, the drop in production is nearly 20 per cent," says a July 1 research note from Bank of Baroda (BoB). It attributes the lower tomato production to adverse climatic conditions.

Lower production has been the biggest contributor to the high tomato prices, say those who are part of the vegetable supply chain. In Mumbai, tomato prices have breached the Rs 200 mark in most prominent markets such as Khar, Dadar, Matunga, Andheri, Parel and Byculla. Making matters worse was a landslide in Lonavala that held up traffic on July 24 for hours on the Mumbai-Pune expressway. Tomato wholesale prices at the Vashi APMC (agricultural produce market committee) market were in the range of Rs 90-110 a kg, as tomato supply had fallen by 40 per cent.

"Tomato prices were very low for some eight to nine months, falling to Rs 5-10 a kg earlier this year. Given the low prices, farmers did not plant new crops. This led to a shortage all over India for the past 30-45 days," explains Shankar Pingale, director of the Vashi APMC. From 70-80 trucks of tomatoes every day, the number has now fallen to 30-40 here. "We estimate the shortfall in cargo to be somewhere close to 40 per cent," Pingale says. Each truck carries anywhere between 4 and 8 tonnes of tomatoes. There used to be days when the market would see around 640 tonnes coming in. But that's history now. Usually, by this time, tomatoes from Karnataka and Gujarat should have come to Mumbai. However, due to the shortage, whatever is produced in a particular state is consumed in that state itself. The delayed onset of monsoon also destroyed whatever new crops the farmer had sown. "The government can take any step, but, ultimately, there should be produce with the farmer for him to sell," Pingale adds.

The BoB report corroborates this point. "Data shows that tomato production has moderated by 0.4 per cent from 20.7 million tonnes (MT) in 2021-22 to 20.6 MT as per the first advance estimates of 2022-23," it says. The rabi harvest of tomatoes lingers till May-June. "Thus, the crop might have been impacted due to heat waves or erratic rainfall, and hence, there is a sudden upward in prices. But with the July-November arrival of crops, some easing of the trajectory might

A PRICEY VEGETABLE

₹30*
RETAIL PRICES IN MAY 2023

₹200*
RETAIL PRICES AS ON JULY 25

40%
SUPPLY SHORTFALL IN VASHI (MUMBAI) APMC

20.6
MILLION TONNES INDIA'S TOTAL ESTIMATED TOMATO PRODUCTION IN FY2022-23

23.9%
CULTIVATION SHORTFALL IN GUJARAT

** Per kg in Mumbai*

WHY TOMATOES ARE EXPENSIVE

- Tomato production declined in Gujarat, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and Chhattisgarh due to either heat waves or erratic rainfall
- Prices were very low for some eight to nine months, falling to Rs 5-10 a kg earlier this year. In view of the low prices, farmers did not plant new crops, leading to shortages
- The delayed southwest monsoon destroyed whatever new crop was sown



P AKHILESH

PRECIOUS FEW Tomato farmers in the Junnar taluka of Pune district, Maharashtra, July 5